NO TAKERS FOR THE VACCINE

THANKS TO SOCIAL STIGMA AND LACK OF AWARENESS, THOUSANDS OF WOMEN CONTINUE TO DIE OF CERVICAL CANCER IN INDIA, EVEN THOUGH IT IS THE ONLY TYPE THAT'S ALMOST ENTIRELY PREVENTABLE BY A VACCINE

By Sonali Acharjee

IT STARTED IN EARLY 2022, with a few spots of blood between menstrual cycles. Aditi Sharma (*name changed*), 38, then a Ph.D. student in Delhi, didn't tell anyone; she had just broken up with her partner and begun seeing someone else. The bleeding stopped in a few hours, but just a day later, she experienced intense pain during sexual intercourse. "I thought it would pass," says Sharma. The spotting and the pelvic pain remained intermittent and Sharma kept dealing with them with over-the-counter painkillers. It was only when she started having trouble breathing that she knew something was terribly wrong. "My friends had to rush me to the ICU," she says. Within a few hours of reaching the hospital, Sharma's life took a turn that she continues to grapple with even today. She was diagnosed with advanced stage cervical cancer,

and a particularly aggressive version of it, which had spread to her lungs. Sharma has been under treatment for nearly two years now. "I have had two long surgeries, and I cannot have children now as my uterus had to be removed," she says. She has also been through several sessions of chemotherapy and radiation, and may have to undergo treatment for the rest of her life to prevent relapse. Things would have been different if only she had reached out for medical attention on time. "But I was too ashamed to talk of vaginal bleeding," says Sharma. "I thought my parents would come to know I had sex."

Sharma is still among the luckier ones. Only one in two—or 51 per cent—of women diagnosed of the disease in India come out of it alive, according to a study published in *The Lancet* in 2023. India also accounts for the highest number of cervical cancer cases in Asia. Around 96,922 women are diagnosed with it on an average every year in the country, of which 60,078 succumb to the disease, according to estimates from the HPV Information Centre. Usually caused by the human papillomavirus (HPV), cervical cancer is transmitted through sexual activity. Within the country, it is the second most common cancer among women after breast cancer, which, at 80 per cent, has a better survival rate. The glaring irony? Cervical cancer is entirely avoidable.

For, it is the only cancer for which a vaccine has been available for 17 years, one that can prevent this cancer almost entirely. True, India had to import HPV vaccines until last year and they would cost around Rs 3,000 to Rs 4,000 per